AI for Africa, by Africa
UNESCO's Commitment to the AI for Africa Initiative

I. Context

Artificial Intelligence (AI) is rapidly transforming societies worldwide, reshaping governance, education, culture, health, agriculture, and industry. For Africa, home to the world's fastest-growing youth population and extraordinary cultural and linguistic diversity, AI represents a historic opportunity to accelerate sustainable development and cultural renaissance, as set out in the African Union (AU)'s **Agenda 2063: The Africa We Want.** Yet without strong governance, inclusive skills development, adequate infrastructure, and investment in local languages, this opportunity faces real challenges.

The challenges are stark. The continent contributes roughly 3% of global AI talent, while an estimated 70,000 skilled professionals leave each year. This is not just a brain drain but an innovation drain, limiting Africa's ability to shape its own AI future. Internet penetration stands at about 37% compared to a global average of 67%, and approximately only 5% of Africa's AI researchers report access to the computing resources required for modern AI development. Global large language models (LLMs) remain poorly adapted to African languages, raising risks of reduced usability and representation. And, only a small proportion of the countries assessed by UNESCO have the institutional capacity to address AI's ethical implications.

Yet the potential is immense: AI could generate $1.2 trillion for Africa's economy by 2030, equivalent to 6% of its GDP. Recognizing this, the African Union adopted its first Continental AI Strategy in 2024, developed in close collaboration with UNESCO. **The AI for Africa Initiative**, launched jointly by UNESCO, the AU and G20, is an operational mechanism for multilateral cooperation in the delivery of this Strategy, structured around its action areas. Together, the Strategy sets the vision, and the Initiative contributes to its implementation.

II. Coherent Mandate on Artificial Intelligence

UNESCO's comparative advantage lies in its ability to set and translate global standards into regional strategies and national action. It brings together its three core functions: norm-setting, policy development, and capacity building into a coherent approach that is driven by international cooperation, responding to continental and national needs.

- **At the global level,** UNESCO developed the Recommendation on the Ethics of AI, adopted by all 193 Member States in 2021, and hosts the annual Global Forum on the Ethics of AI. UNESCO also supported the creation of the G20's Technology Policy Assistance Facility - a one-stop hub that translates AI governance guidance into practice with an interactive policy design tool and on-demand expert support. In addition, UNESCO participates in the G20 Digital Economy Working Group and has contributed to its Toolkit to Reduce Inequalities in AI. In partnership with UNDP, ITU, and the African Union, UNESCO created the Data Governance Toolkit to support the AI ecosystem, adapting it to non-going needs and helping develop the AI Competency Framework for civil servants.
- **At the regional level,** UNESCO's partnership in the 2025 AI for Africa Conference follows support to the development of the AU Continental AI Strategy and co-organization of Africa-wide AI fora (Continental: Morocco, 2018, Southern Africa: Namibia, 2022 and East Africa: Kenya, 2024) to strengthen dialogue and cooperation.

- **At the national level,** UNESCO's Readiness Assessment Methodology (RAM) has been deployed in over 80 countries, 29 of which are in Africa, providing evidence-based guidance for policy design, governance frameworks, and institutional capacity.

This continuum ensures Africa is not only a consumer of AI but a co-creator of its digital future.

III. Impact and Institutional Commitments

UNESCO is committed to supporting the implementation of all eight pillars of the AI for Africa Initiative, aligning global standards with Africa's priorities and national realities. Its specific immediate commitments focus on three priority action areas of the Initiative:

1. **Developing Robust AI Governance:** To date, UNESCO's RAM exercise has produced national reports in 9 of the 29 African countries engaged, helping to shape AI strategies and governance frameworks in countries such as Morocco, Namibia, Nigeria, Senegal, and Zimbabwe. The Recommendation on the Ethics of AI is now embedded in the AU's Continental Strategy, aligning global principles with African priorities. Looking ahead, UNESCO will extend RAM to the remaining African countries, stands ready to support the AU in crafting five sectoral AI strategies, as well as train 10,000 executive-level professionals across Africa on AI, through the Technology Policy Assistance Facility, helping shape ethical, inclusive, and future-ready AI governance across Africa.
2. AI Workforce, Education and Capacity Building: UNESCO has already trained civil servants, judicial actors, and over 1,000 women and youth on AI. Building on this momentum, it will scale up efforts to train 15,000 civil servants and 5,000 judicial actors during 2026-2027. To further strengthen local capacity, the African AI Talent Incubator - to be launched in Nigeria, South Africa, Rwanda, and Egypt, could equip 1,500 young researchers and professionals with advanced, hands-on AI skills. Moreover, the Africa-Asia Youth Coding Initiative will expand to reach 2,000 teachers and students across Africa, helping to cultivate the continent's next generation of AI innovators. UNESCO's AI Competency Framework will be contextualized to African education systems, with a pilot project involving Benin, Burundi, Côte d'Ivoire, and Senegal, in collaboration with the Global Partnership for Education's Knowledge and Innovation Exchange Africa 21 Hub. Additionally, the PrepAI initiative will engage at least 15 African countries to train senior education policymakers on AI.
3. **AI for Inclusive and Sustainable Development:** UNESCO has advanced AI applications in education, justice, public administration, and culture, while supporting women-led AI enterprises and promoting linguistic diversity in Africa. Looking ahead, UNESCO aims to increase the number of incubated enterprises by the next biennium and deploy AI solutions for climate resilience, wildfire detection, water management, and biodiversity protection, targeting the most vulnerable regions in Southern Africa. It will also train young talents to apply AI for disaster risk reduction and expand Media and Information Literacy (MIL) programs to empower African educators, youth, and creators to critically engage with AI, countering risks from poorly adapted global LLMs.

Conclusion

As the UN agency with Africa as its global priority and the first and only standard-setting instrument on the ethical use of AI, UNESCO stands united with the African Union, the G20, and partners to ignite Africa's leadership in AI development and governance, shaping it for people, prosperity, and the planet. This Initiative is a rallying call for African innovators, policymakers, as well as international and African investors: traditional and new, public and private, to drive this transformation. With Africans leading and global partnerships fueling progress, AI can unlock inclusive, ethical growth and serve as a powerful springboard to deliver the bold aspirations of the African Union's Agenda 2063.

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